

competent composer who attained some renown as the author of a manual on violin technique, but the family was both short of money and low in status, living in a rented apartment above a grocery shop.

Musical prodigy

Wolfgang Amadeus was the seventh and last child in the family, and the second to survive. His sister Maria Anna, known as Nannerl, was four years his senior. Taught by their father, both children proved exceptionally gifted, but Wolfgang exceeded his sister in talent and precocity. He could play pieces on the keyboard at the age of four and created his first simple compositions at age five. Realizing that his son was a prodigy, Leopold embarked on a campaign to exploit the opportunity this presented for immediate financial gain and for the child's longer-term success in life. In 1762, the Mozarts set off on the first of a series of show tours that were to continue for more than a decade. Leopold took both children to perform in Munich and then in Vienna, where they were exhibited to the formidable Austrian Hapsburg empress Maria Theresa at the Schönbrunn Palace. Showing a disregard for social distances that was to last through his life, Wolfgang spontaneously kissed the empress. Royals, nobles, and ambassadors were suitably impressed by the children's precocious musical skills but, whether because of Wolfgang's inappropriate embrace or Leopold's upstart pushiness, they did not win the empress's patronage.